



A PAGE FOR COLLECTORS. MORE ABOUT THE UNICORN.

By FRANK DAVIS.

THE familiar mediæval unicorn of the nursery rhyme and the heraldist was described and explained in these pages (March 21 issue) in a very interesting article by Mr. G. R. Bellew, Somerset Herald. As he says, "Belief in the actual existence of unicorns was still prevalent in the seventeenth century," but the famous example at Windsor Castle must have been very soon identified for what it actually was. Here is a quotation from "Purchas His Pilgrimes"—"The fourth voyage of James Hall to Groeneland, 1612. Written by William Baffin": "As for the Sea Unicorne, it being a great fish, having a long horne or bone, growing forth of his forehead or nostril . . . in divers places we saw of them, which if the horne be of any good value, no doubt but many of them may be killed." He adds a note: "The horne is still kept in the Robes at Windsor (where I have seene it) neere seven foot long and cressed." A very matter-of-fact sailorman, this William Baffin, and less amenable to tall stories than Anthony Knivet, whose adventures in the South Seas are to be found in the same collection (1597). "At this Towne," he writes, "all our men, both Indians and Portugals, fell sicke by eating of a kind of sweet pleasant fruit that was poyson, and had it not been for a Gentleman who had a piece of Unicorne's horne, we had all died." Then, as now, faith and a sturdy constitution could perform miracles of healing.

But I am merely embroidering a tale already well told. Let us consider this self-same pious animal from a different angle. Whatever the origin of the unicorn in the zoological sense—oryx or rhinoceros or both—his hold on the imagination



1. THE UNICORN IN THE EAST: AN IVORY NETSUKE IN THE FORM OF A KIRIN (OR, JAPANESE UNICORN), WITH ITS HORN CURVED BACK OVER ITS HEAD.

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of the fierceness ascribed to him by our own mediæval stories. "At the proximity of a virtuous damsel all his ferocity departed," writes Mr. Bellew of the heraldic unicorn. "His strident cries would cease immediately and give place to joyful whinnies. Approaching the maiden with peace in his heart, he would then lay his head in her lap and fall fast asleep. And thus he fell an easy victim to those who desired to encompass his destruction." Note two points in this account—first, the extremely unsportsmanlike proceeding; and secondly, the insistence upon virginity as the greatest of all virtues, so characteristic of the Middle Ages. I should not care to be dogmatic about so fantastic a legend, but it is tempting to see some sort of connecting link between the Far Eastern animal and his European counterpart in an odd little story from India. Once upon a time, there was a magical beast rather resembling our unicorn, whose father was a hermit and whose mother a doe. During the rainy season, it slipped on the mud and broke a jar, and angrily commanded the gods to stop all rain for ever. Drought burnt up the kingdom of Benares, and no grass grew and the people perished, so that the king in desperation promised half his realm to whoever would persuade the creature to alter his mind. The pious romancer of Europe would inevitably have told how a beautiful and virtuous girl braved the terrors of the desert, and by her innocence and fearless blue eyes charmed away the monster's evil passions—but alas for virtue! the story goes on to relate that the land was freed, and that speedily, by the blandishments of a famous courtesan.

I illustrate in Fig. 1 the Japanese interpretation of the unicorn in the shape of a very fine *netsuke*, the little pendant or toggle fastened at the end of a cord by which purse or seal-case or snuff-bottle was slung from the girdle. The horn, it will be noticed, is curved back over the head, and, as far as

I know, this seems to be the characteristic shape in the Far East. The beautiful jade of Fig. 4—to my mind a piece of the highest artistic quality—is an admirable example of the Chinese understanding of animal form. Time and again one is astonished not only by their skill in sculpture, but by their uncanny interpretation of the spirit of the wilderness. Here also the small horn lies back upon the head.

Lest anyone should be tempted to jump to conclusions about this fascinating beast, I illustrate two other pieces to show how varied was the Chinese imagination, and how vague the distinction between one fabulous animal and another. I suppose the very ancient buckle in brown jade (Fig. 2) is ornamented with the head of a dragon. The single horn in the centre tempts one to call it a unicorn, but there are two others as well. As for the carp of Fig. 3, these, too, have a single horn sloping back over their heads, but they are certainly in process of being changed into dragons. The fable—a delightful conceit—will bear repetition. There is a certain cataract in the western hills which the carp try to climb. It requires all their perseverance, and those that succeed become dragons, and immortal. So at the entrance to the examination hall at Nanking was a painting representing a carp passing through the Dragon Gateway. Thus would the aspirant for official

2. PERHAPS A CLOSE RELATIVE OF THE UNICORN! A CHINESE DRAGON, ON AN OLD BUCKLE, WHICH WEARS A HORN IN THE MIDDLE OF ITS FOREHEAD, LIKE A KYLIN—AND ONE ON EACH SIDE AS WELL.

This is a very ancient buckle in brown jade. On the shaft, in low relief, is a Phoenix, the personal symbol of the Empress.

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position work hard and pass through the difficult gateway of learning to the honourable dignities and emoluments of the Civil Service.



3. A STUDY IN MYTHOLOGICAL "EVOLUTION": WINGED CARP WHICH BEAR SINGLE HORNS ON THEIR FOREHEADS, LIKE KYLINS, OR UNICORNS, BECAUSE THEY ARE "IN PROCESS OF BEING CHANGED INTO DRAGONS."

This delightful Imperial white jade vase, of eighteenth-century provenance, refers to a charming Chinese fable which relates that, at a certain cataract in the western hills, the carp who climb to the top of the waterfall are forthwith changed into dragons and become immortal, as a reward for their perseverance!

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of man must have been fairly general centuries before the science of heraldry began to exercise the mind of Europe, and his representation in Chinese art can be traced from the Han Dynasty at least, without of course, any heraldic significance. Just as the European legend makes him the emblem of chastity,



4. A CHINESE KYLIN (OR, UNICORN), WITH ITS HORN TURNED BACK ON ITS HEAD LIKE THE JAPANESE KIRIN PICTURED IN FIG. 1: A MASTERPIECE IN GREY JADE OF THE KHANG HSI DYNASTY (1662-1722).

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